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"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, windy, cooler temperatures, clouds giving way to sun, gusty winds, high 55. **Tonight,** clear, chilly, low 41. **Tomorrow,** Sunny, high 58. Weather map appears on Page B12.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,040 © 2026 The New York Times Company SATURDAY, OCTOBER 17, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00

Trump Fires Press Officer After 5 Days

An Apparent Falsehood Raised Eyebrows

This article is by ***Shawn McCreesh****,* ***Tyler Pager*** *and* ***Hamed Aleaziz****.*

President Trump's new press secretary, Katie Zacharia, was forced out of her role Friday after five days on the job, a rare reversal by the White House that capped a week of upheaval.



Katie Zacharia

Ms. Zacharia, who had gained Mr. Trump's attention as a conservative commentator, had gotten off to a shaky start with her first and only press briefing on Tuesday. She largely read off a script and ended questioning after just five and a half minutes. That was followed by an onslaught of headlines about whether she had misrepresented herself as a lawyer — the president called her "an attorney" — despite failing her bar exam.

Subsequent interviews she gave in the media, in which she tried to defend herself by pointing out how unprepared she had been to go before the Washington press corps, also went poorly.

Finally, after days of unrelenting press coverage, the Trump administration decided on Friday afternoon to do something it almost never does: It folded.

Mr. Trump was walking across the South Lawn to depart for a midterm rally in Georgia when he stopped to talk to reporters, telling them how he'd just encouraged his press secretary to "reconsider" her new job.

"Honestly, if I were you, I'd reconsider," he told the reporters, recounting his conversation with her. "Katie, do you need this? I don't think you need this."

Continued on Page A18



JEDRZEJ NOWICKI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Mark Horskyi, 10, in his bedroom after a day of air raid sirens and bombings, said he thinks, "God, help us," after every explosion.

A New Kind of Battlefield: Life in Kyiv

Danger in Daily Tasks as Russian Strikes Aim to Make City Unlivable

This article is by ***Kim Barker****,* ***Maria Varenikova*** *and* ***Oleksandra Mykolyshyn****.*

KYIV, Ukraine — The air-raid alarm went off at 3:11 a.m. but offered little warning. Within three minutes, the missiles started to hit, almost 10 teeth-rattling booms that jolted Nikita Horskyi and Alona Horska awake.

The couple launched into what has become a familiar ritual in recent weeks. Mr. Horskyi scooped up their two children. Ms. Horska assembled makeshift beds in the hallway. Their 16-story apartment building has no shelter, and they knew that two walls offered more protection than the exterior wall alone.

Mark, their 10-year-old, thought, "God, help us," as he said he does after every explosion. He hugged his stuffed goose and curled up in the hallway on a thin mat and a pillow resembling a smiling green monster. Arina, 5, lay down on a blowup bed with sheets of pastel bunnies and hedgehogs.

The family fell back asleep, accustomed to this particular nightmare, until the next missiles hit, two of them nearby, including one that killed a pair of security guards. Mark woke to the sound of glass shattering outside. He fell asleep for a bit longer, then he and his sister got up for school. Soon the jet-powered drones would arrive.

"Of course, it affects my mental state and my nerves," Mark said. "I have to come up with things to calm myself down."

This is the story of the Ukrainian capital, Kyiv, on a recent day, and how life here has deteriorated. The Russian missiles come more often, not just at night but all day.

Continued on Page A9

BUDGET FOR U.S. NEARS A DEFICIT OF $2 TRILLION

WIDEST GAP SINCE 2021

Deep Concern in Market About the Debt and Rising Inflation

By ALAN RAPPEPORT

WASHINGTON — The United States budget deficit approached $2 trillion in the 2026 fiscal year, its highest level since the pandemic, as spending on the military, safety net programs and interest on the debt dwarfed the Trump administration's cost cuts, Treasury Department figures showed on Friday.

The widening gap between what the government spends and what it collects in taxes and other revenue comes at a critical moment. Investors are nervous about America's surging debt load, along with stubborn inflation, and have driven up borrowing costs. Treasury bond yields, which influence interest rates for mortgages, credit cards and auto loans, hit their highest levels in two decades earlier this month before easing.

Those higher borrowing costs come as many Americans, already feeling beleaguered by the cost of living, head to the polls for an election that will determine whether Republicans retain control of Congress. While the deficit has been driven up by spending and tax decisions by both political parties, President Trump and Republicans added to the shortfall with an expensive tax cut package in 2025. Mr. Trump, who had promised to curb federal spending, has instead seen it rise on his watch.

The rising deficit, which increased to $1.99 trillion this fiscal year from $1.78 trillion in 2025, is notable because it comes at a time when the economy is growing steadily. The last time the deficit

Continued on Page A18

The Private Eye Alleged to Hack Climate Efforts

By KAREN ZRAICK and GABBY SOBELMAN

For decades, an Israeli private investigator named Amit Forlit has operated on the edges of international intrigue while rubbing elbows with powerful figures.

Mr. Forlit claims to have served in Shin Bet, Israel's internal security agency. He dated a prominent Israeli businesswoman and social-media figure who photographed him at exclusive parties. And he may or may not have inspired a hacker-for-hire character in a 2022 novel about murky financial shenanigans involving Argentine debt.

These were mostly bit parts in other people's dramas. Until now.

Today Mr. Forlit, wearing an ankle monitor while remaining in the New York City area, awaits trial in a globe-spanning hacking case where he is the central character. Prosecutors with the Justice Department have charged him with overseeing an operation that aimed to discredit American environmentalists, allegedly on behalf of a huge oil company. He has pleaded not guilty.

Mr. Forlit could face decades in prison.

The charges, filed in the U.S. District Court for the Southern District of New York, allege a "sprawling criminal enterprise" in which Mr. Forlit and his associates hired hackers in India to gain unauthorized access to the envi-

Continued on Page A7



JORDAN GALE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Silver Rail Elementary School on Friday in Bend, Ore., a day after an attack by a former student.

Armed Parent and a Teacher Ended a Rampage

Oregon Shooting Could Have Been Deadlier

This article is by ***Anna Griffin****,* ***Chelsia Rose Marcius*** *and* ***Michael Levenson****.*

BEND, Ore. — The police in Oregon on Friday detailed the heroic actions that prevented a school shooting from becoming even deadlier, saying that a teacher had tried to wrestle the attacker's shotgun away before another adult fatally shot him.

Three children, ages 5, 8 and 11, and a 25-year-old teacher were killed in the rampage at Silver Rail Elementary School in Bend, Ore., on Thursday. A 7-year-old and a 54-year-old teacher were critically injured.

The police said the attack had been carried out by a 16-year-old former student at the school who was armed with a 12-gauge pump-action shotgun.

They said he had blasted open locks on a side door at the school and had gone to a special education classroom, where he fired at least 15 rounds.

A teacher in the classroom threw her cellphone at the shooter, tackled him and tried to wrestle his shotgun from him, the police said.

"She was not injured in that incident," Mike Krantz, the Bend police chief, said at a news conference on Friday. "But she almost

Continued on Page A19

What Maine Rivals for Senate Share: Roots in the Wilderness

By ESMÉ E. DEPREZ and JENNA RUSSELL

AROOSTOOK COUNTY, Maine — The story of northern Maine is the story of rural America: Fewer jobs, a declining population and a deeply ingrained feeling of being forgotten, or looked down upon, by the liberal population centers calling the shots.

That sense of alienation helped fuel the rise of President Trump. It has also shaped the critical U.S. Senate contest in Maine, where both candidates — Senator Susan Collins, the Republican incumbent, and Troy Jackson, the Democratic challenger — grew up in Aroostook County, a vast wilderness bordered by Canada on three sides and defined by its geographic isolation.

Each candidate refers often to their roots in "The County," as Mainers know it. During their final debate on Thursday night, responding to a pointed question from Mr. Jackson about her respect for working-class voters, Ms. Collins again noted her Aroostook County roots and her first job there picking potatoes.

Ms. Collins, 73, first won her seat in 1996. By now, almost everyone in Maine knows that she helped out in the fields during harvest breaks from school in Caribou, where her ancestors founded a lumber business in 1844.

But it is Mr. Jackson, a fifth-generation logger who grew up poor in the remote St. John Valley, who is trying to ride the populist wave that first lifted Mr. Trump.



SOPHIE PARK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The landscape of Aroostook County, Maine, ranges from dense woods to potato fields.

Mr. Jackson, 58, a longtime state lawmaker, has credited his hardscrabble upbringing in Aroostook for giving him a keen awareness of economic disparities, a suspicion of corporate power and a drive to deliver more affordable housing and health care in a state where incomes lag behind the rest of New England.

He has described himself as "somebody with grease on their hands" who "talks funny, didn't go to the right school." To powerful people, "that is what we are — nobodies," he has said.

Ms. Collins has won her home county decisively in all five of her previous elections. But to some

Continued on Page A16





NATIONAL A12-19, 22

Young Voters Leave Trump
In 2024, young voters turned away from Democrats. They are swinging back in the midterms. PAGE A12

Stumping in Michigan
Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez joined Dr. Abdul El-Sayed in a key Senate race. PAGE A13

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Settlers Attack Palestinians
In the latest surge of violence, Israelis targeted a group in the West Bank during the olive harvest, a cultural touchstone and economic lifeline. PAGE A6

Albanian Protests Turn Violent
Anger over the cost of living and corruption spurred demands that the prime minister resign. PAGE A11

BUSINESS B1-5

A Chat With Rogue A.I. Bots
Researchers made contact with agents from China they found trying to bypass security controls on websites. PAGE B4



SPORTS B6-9

Milwaukee's New Folk Heroes
After a 44-year World Series drought, a new crew of characters for the Brewers has a chance to prove, at last, that it can win a championship. PAGE B8

OBITUARIES B10-11

Evangelist Who Came Clean
An ordained minister at 4, Marjoe Gortner went on to star in a documentary that revealed the flimflammery of his former profession. He was 82. PAGE B10

TRAVEL C7-8

Harvest Season on the Road
Five hours northwest of New York City is a region of 9,000 square miles with 11 glacial lakes, rolling farmland and countless waterfalls. PAGE C8

OPINION A20-21

The Editorial Board PAGE A20



ARTS C1-6

Building Her Own Big Tent
The Colombian musical star Karol G has become adept at mixing the sounds of her home country with a broader palette of Latin music. PAGE C1

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